assurances given by President Kennedy three days earlier that there would be no involvement by the American military or American citizens in the Cuban crisis. Countering Roa's claims that it was US planes that bombed Cuba, Stevenson produced a photograph of a plane that had landed earlier that day at Miami airport in Florida. It was a B-26 bomber painted in the colors of the Cuban air force, and its pilot had told reporters that he had taken part in a bombing raid organized and executed by anti-Castro officers in his country's air force. Unbeknownst to Stevenson, the landing of the plane was part of a CIA operation aimed at misleading international public opinion.[16]

With ships in the water and planes in the air, the CIA-trained teams still needed a final go-ahead from President Kennedy. His deadline for that decision was noon on Sunday, April 16. The day began on a sour note. Articles published that morning in some of the leading US newspapers exposed the CIA operation involving the plane landing at Miami as a cover-up of a US-backed attack on Cuba. Reporters noticed that the gun on the B-26 had not been fired and that the airplane was a different model from those used by the Cubans. Kennedy was vacillating. He and his wife, Jacqueline, went to Mass at the local Catholic church and then had lunch with family members. After that, the president went off to play golf. The noon deadline for his decision had long passed, but he could not make up his mind. Finally, he returned to his house around 1:45 p.m. and called Bissell at the CIA: the invasion could go ahead.

Late on the night of April 16, the landing of Brigade 2506 began at multiple locations on the island. In the early hours of April 17 four transport ships approached Playa Girón in the Bay of Pigs. It was an isolated place and, with no Cuban military units around, the exiles easily overwhelmed the local militia fighters. But they were in for a major surprise: the remote location of the landing failed to ensure its secrecy. A Cuban radio operator managed to broadcast news of the invasion before his unit was overtaken by the brigade. When Castro was alerted, he ordered the airplanes that had survived the initial attack (including Lockheed T-33 fighter jets and B-26 bombers) into action.

The invaders had little air cover: the surviving Cuban planes outnumbered the six aircraft provided by the CIA to support Brigade 2506.